

30 Minutes Expert

Partition your Hard Disk

Computers today ship with hard drives that are more than 8 or 10 GB large. To use this huge space effectively you can split it into smaller logical divisions using Partitioning software. However, most users find the task quite daunting. This 30-minute guide is aimed at making you comfortable with the nitty gritty of hard disk partitioning. We are using the software called BootIT NG, which you can also find on the cover CD.

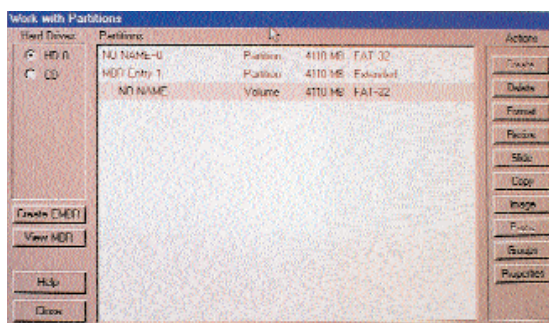
Creating the BootIT NG boot disks

You need to first create a boot disk of BootIT NG. Unzip the installation files to a temporary directory. Launch the single executable file in the unzipped collection. Leave the settings in the following window as default.

The application prompts you to insert a floppy to start the boot-disk creation process. The application erases all the data in the floppy and copies the necessary partition manager software and a small OS that will be required to boot the PC. Once the boot-disk creation process is complete you can press [Esc] to close the application. You now have a bootable floppy ready for the actual exercise.

Divide and Rule!

STEP 1 Now you are all set to start the disk partitioning process. Insert the bootable disk into the floppy drive and reboot your computer. (Check your BIOS settings to ensure that the first boot device is set to floppy).



Partition window lists the drives and the partitions

STEP 2 When your computer boots through the floppy it opens a graphical interface with mouse support. When you are prompted with the BootIT NG installation on your hard disk, click 'Cancel' and enter the maintenance mode (a message window states that you are entering the maintenance mode).

STEP 3 When you enter the maintenance mode you will see a screen with the following options listed:

- Settings
- Partition Work
- Resume
- Backup
- Restore
- Reboot



Leave the options in 'Settings' at default. Resume takes you to the BootIT NG hard disk install screen. BootIT NG can also act as a backup and a restore utility and hence the options of Backup/Restore. The Reboot option lets you reboot your machine to effect any changes you make.

STEP 4 Click on Partition Work. This opens a window that displays your hard drive as 'HD0' ('HD1' for a second hard drive and so on). Your CD-ROM is also listed in a similar manner.

STEP 5 Choose 'HD0' and then click on the Create button to the right of the screen. This throws open a popup window where you are required to choose the file system you would like the first partition to be formatted with. Choose '11/bh Fat32' from the drop-down list. It's the only FAT32 option available.

STEP 6 In the text area provided, enter the size of the partition you would like to create. Plan before you create partitions. If you have a 20 GB hard disk you might want to create four logical drives of 5 GB capacity each.

STEP 7 Click OK. You will be prompted with a message box that asks you whether you would like to convert this partition into NTFS. Click No and the partitioning process starts. It's done in three phases. First is allocation, then error checking and then formatting. All this happens as a background process.

Your first partition is now created. You can repeat these steps to create more partitions with the remaining free space. You are ready to use the space on your hard disk in an efficient way.

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Resizing a Partition

You can also use BootIT NG to resize partitions on your hard disk. However, be aware that though you can resize partitions with the data present on them, there is a chance that you could end up losing data. So, clean up the partition before you resize.

STEP 1 Choose the partition that you would like to resize. Click on 'Properties' on the right and in the window that pops up click on the 'Free' button to look up how much free space is left on the partition. Click 'OK' to close the window.

STEP 2 Press [Alt]+[R] or click on the

'Resize' button to the right of the screen.

STEP 3 In the window that pops up, enter the size of the partition. Click 'OK' to continue. The software warns you with a message on the possibility of losing data. Click 'OK' and initiate the resizing process.

STEP 4 If successfully resized, the software checks for errors on the partition and shows a success message. Click 'Close' to complete the resizing exercise.

STEP 5 If you have made the partition smaller, the free space is listed in the main details screen.